

Primary Source Reading: Nietzsche's *Beyond Good and Evil* (Preface and Sections 1–6)

Philosophy Honors: Ethics / Lesson 1.05 — Is There a Fact About What Is Good? Translated by Helen Zimmern (1907)

Before you read: Nietzsche opens by comparing the philosophical search for Truth to a clumsy suitor who has never actually won over the woman he pursues. As you read, notice what he thinks philosophers have gotten wrong — not that they reached false conclusions, but something about *how* and *why* they reached them at all.

Preface: The Dogmatists' Failed Courtship

SUPPOSING that Truth is a woman—what then? Is there not ground for suspecting that all philosophers, in so far as they have been dogmatists, have failed to understand women—that the terrible seriousness and clumsy importunity with which they have usually paid their addresses to Truth, have been unskilled and unseemly methods for winning a woman? Certainly she has never allowed herself to be won; and at present every kind of dogma stands with sad and discouraged mien.

Section 1: The Value of the Will to Truth

The Will to Truth, which is to tempt us to many a hazardous enterprise, the famous Truthfulness of which all philosophers have hitherto spoken with respect, what questions has this Will to Truth not laid before us!... We inquired about the VALUE of this Will. Granted that we want the truth: WHY NOT RATHER untruth? And uncertainty? Even ignorance? The problem of the value of truth presented itself before us—or was it we who presented ourselves before the problem?

Section 2: The Belief in Antitheses of Values

“HOW COULD anything originate out of its opposite? For example, truth out of error? or the Will to Truth out of the will to deception? or the generous deed out of selfishness? ... Such genesis is impossible; whoever dreams of it is a fool, nay, worse than a fool; things of the highest value must have a different origin, an origin of THEIR own.” This mode of reasoning discloses the typical prejudice by which metaphysicians of all times can be recognized... The fundamental belief of metaphysicians is THE BELIEF IN ANTITHESES OF VALUES. It never occurred even to the wariest of them to doubt here on the very threshold.

Section 3: Philosophical Thinking as Instinct

Having kept a sharp eye on philosophers, and having read between their lines long enough, I now say to myself that the greater part of conscious thinking must be counted among the instinctive functions... the greater part of the conscious thinking

of a philosopher is secretly influenced by his instincts, and forced into definite channels. And behind all logic and its seeming sovereignty of movement, there are valuations, or to speak more plainly, physiological demands, for the maintenance of a definite mode of life.

Section 4: Untruth as a Condition of Life

The falseness of an opinion is not for us any objection to it: it is here, perhaps, that our new language sounds most strangely. The question is, how far an opinion is life-furthering, life-preserving, species-preserving, perhaps species-rearing... TO RECOGNISE UNTRUTH AS A CONDITION OF LIFE; that is certainly to impugn the traditional ideas of value in a dangerous manner, and a philosophy which ventures to do so, has thereby alone placed itself beyond good and evil.

Sections 5–6: Philosophy as Confession

That which causes philosophers to be regarded half-distrustfully and half-mockingly, is not the oft-repeated discovery how innocent they are... but that there is not enough honest dealing with them... They are all advocates who do not wish to be regarded as such, generally astute defenders, also, of their prejudices, which they dub “truths.” ... The spectacle of the Tartuffery of old Kant, equally stiff and decent, with which he entices us into the dialectic by-ways that lead (more correctly mislead) to his “categorical imperative”—makes us fastidious ones smile.

It has gradually become clear to me what every great philosophy up till now has consisted of—namely, the confession of its originator, and a species of involuntary and unconscious auto-biography; and moreover that the moral (or immoral) purpose in every philosophy has constituted the true vital germ out of which the entire plant has always grown.

After you read: Notice what Nietzsche’s target actually is. He is not primarily attacking any particular moral rule — he is attacking the *pretense* that philosophers reach their moral conclusions through pure, disinterested logic, when in fact (he claims) the conclusion was decided first and the argument constructed afterward to defend it. As the lesson’s discussion prompt asks: does this critique apply to the kind of open-ended questioning Socrates practiced in the *Euthyphro*, where he genuinely did not know the answer in advance — or only to philosophers who arrive already certain of their moral system and merely dress it up in argument? Your one-sentence answer should take a clear position on this distinction.